

Miami Grand Prix – Fastest lap comparison; Antonelli vs Verstappen:

Qualifying at the Miami Grand Prix in 2026 was Kimi Antonelli's first opportunity to demonstrate his ability to achieve a pole position with the strong Mercedes W17 against the four-time World Champion, Max Verstappen.

Below is an overlay of the publicly available telemetry data for both cars, and a follow-up brief discussion on the differences between the two laps:

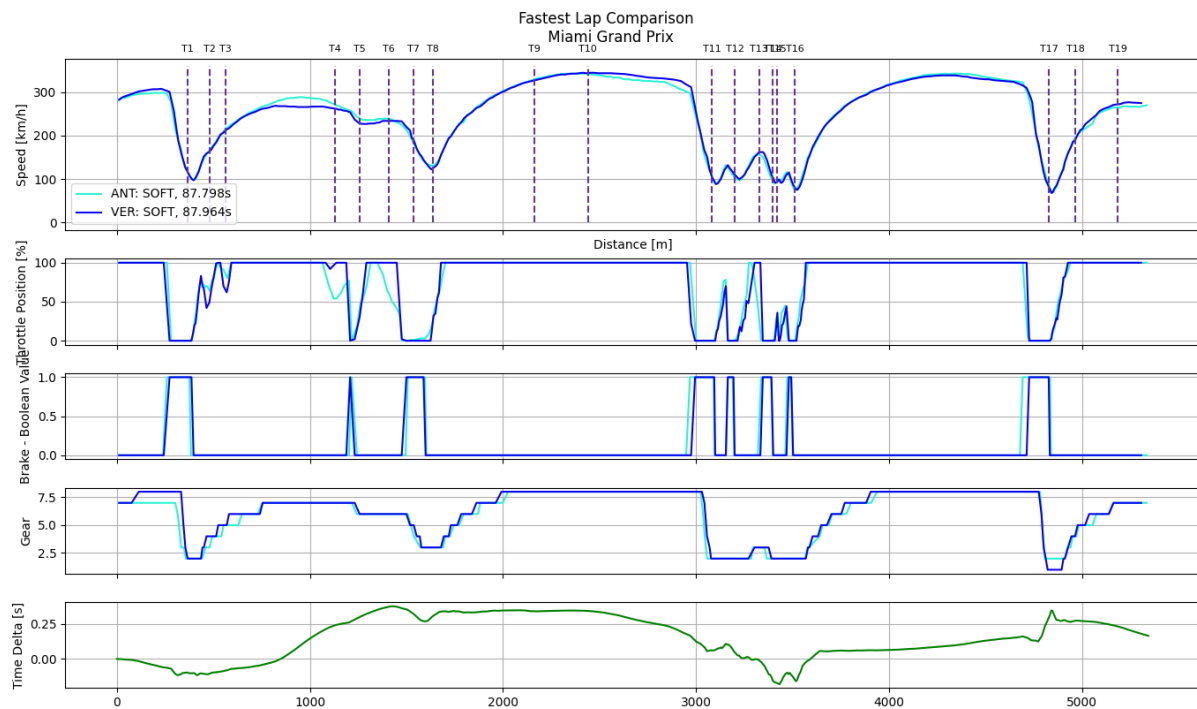


Figure 1: ANT vs VER fastest lap comparison

There are a few interesting things to discuss after reviewing the telemetry we have:

- Verstappen gains an early, but small, advantage on the run to T1: we can see that Verstappen has a ~10 km/h advantage on Antonelli down into T1, with both cars braking at the same point, roughly, allowing Verstappen to have an advantage of ~0.12s. This speed difference at this stage is likely due to the differences in energy deployment strategies between teams; these differences are obvious throughout the lap.
- Antonelli claws back Verstappen's advantage from the exit of T1 to T6: both cars accelerate at roughly the same rate, however between T3 and T4 we see Antonelli have a top-speed advantage of ~22 km/h. This again, is likely due to differences in deployment strategy, but also with Verstappen's lightly decreasing velocity at full throttle indicating that "clipping" is occurring on the Red Bull. This reduced deployment for the Red Bull allows Antonelli to gain a significant margin of ~0.37s over Verstappen, even while lifting more into the entries of T4 and T6.
- Initial acceleration winning Mercedes time: while clipping from T10 to T11 cost Antonelli ~0.14s, and Verstappen gaining an additional ~0.29s through T11 to T16, the increased exit acceleration we see Antonelli gain ~0.1s out of T16, another ~0.1s across the long straight – potentially more efficient, or lower overall downforce, package – with the final corner yielding ~0.17s to the line, ending Verstappen's chance at pole position.

An important note is that battery deployment is not publicly available, and deployment is inferred from both the speed trace, and the time delta trace. T7, T8 and T9 were not ignored, rather no significant differences could be inferred from the available data.